

Parent Guide — middle / module-04-doshas

IKS Curriculum

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Parent Guide — Module 4: Doṣas (Vāta, Pitta, Kapha)

Your child's age: Middle (Grades 6–8) · **Module length:** 10 sessions × 45 min over ~2 weeks

What your child is learning

A classical Indian framework for organising body functions into three categories:

Sanskrit	English meaning	What it governs
<i>vāta</i>	“wind” — motion	Movement, breath, circulation, nervous system
<i>pitta</i>	“that which heats” — transformation	Digestion, metabolism, body temperature, vision
<i>kapha</i>	“phlegm” — structure	Mass, lubrication, immunity, stability

Plus two important pair-concepts:

- ***prakṛti*** — the *baseline* mix of the three a person is born with.
- ***vikṛti*** — the *current* state, which can be out of balance temporarily.

The framework comes from the *Caraka Saṁhitā* (c. 1st millennium BCE/CE), one of the founding texts of Āyurveda.

How we teach it

Three things to know:

1. **Observational, not diagnostic.** Your child is learning to notice. They are NOT learning to diagnose themselves or anyone else.
2. **Lens, not identity.** The class never tells a student “you are a Vāta.” Everyone has all three *doṣas*. *Prakṛti* is a *proportion*, not a label.
3. **Honest about evidence.** We teach where the framework matches modern chronobiology (e.g. why digestion is strongest at midday) and where modern science doesn’t support its more specific claims.

NEP 2020 §4.6 (Integration of Indian Knowledge Systems) and §11.8 (multidisciplinary education) support this approach.

Important safety note

This module makes no medical recommendations.

- No herbal advice. No supplements. No fasting protocols.
- No suggestion that your child change any existing medical care.
- If your child reports any actual symptom — please see a doctor, not the *doṣa* poster.

The framework is a vocabulary for noticing patterns. It is not a substitute for clinical care.

Homework you'll see

- Days 1–3: brief self-observation notes (“when did you feel most alert today?”).
- Days 4–5: small written exercises on the qualities of each *doṣa*.
- Day 6: a six-tastes home tasting (involves common foods — jaggery, lemon, salt, etc.).
Check for allergies.
- Days 8–9: project — design a 5-day “*doṣa*-aware week.”

How to help

Helpful: - Quiz your child gently on the three Sanskrit terms. They should know them by Day 4.
- Talk over your family’s mealtime and sleep habits. Don’t impose change — just notice patterns together.
- For the project: provide poster paper / a phone to film with. Let them write their own plan.

Not helpful: - Telling your child “you’re definitely a Pitta type.” The classroom frame is explicitly *not* that.
- Insisting that classical Ayurveda is “scientifically proven.” It’s a real framework with real history; some parts have modest modern support; some don’t. The honest framing is what we teach.
- Using *doṣa* language to discourage food choices your child enjoys.
This module is not a diet plan.

What success looks like

By end of module, your child can: - Name all three *doṣas* in IAST with their constituent elements.
- Describe at least three qualities of each *doṣa* in plain English.
- Explain the difference between *prakṛti* and *vikṛti*.
- Identify the daily *doṣa* cycle (kapha morning, pitta midday, vāta evening).
- Articulate when *doṣa* language is being used carelessly (e.g. as a fixed identity) vs carefully (as observation).
- Present a 5-day *doṣa*-aware plan with reasoning.

On respect across traditions

Many Indian families use *doṣa* language casually at home. That’s fine. The classroom adds a careful framing — primary-source citation, evidence-honest comparison with chronobiology, and a firm boundary against diagnosis. Both registers can coexist.

Going deeper

Senior band (Grades 9–12) covers the classical *prakṛti* determination at conception (Caraka *Vimānasthāna* 8), the modern Ayurgenomics literature, and a comparative critique with Greek humoral theory. Preview: [curriculum/senior/module-04-doshas/README.md](#).

A note on Module 3 vs Module 4

Module 3 (Āyurveda and Good Health) introduced the three *doṣas* lightly within the broader Ayurveda umbrella. Module 4 is the deep dive — students spend two weeks specifically on the *tridoṣa* framework. Module 10 (separate; not covered here) handles herbs.

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 4 (Middle) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance

Day	Session title	Lesson file	Activity / assessment
1	Where the Doṣas Come From	days/day-01-bridge.md	Pair-share recall of pañcabhūta
2	Three Doṣas in Detail	days/day-02-three-doshas.md	Exit ticket
3	Self-Observation: Your Tendencies	days/day-03-self-observation.md	quizzes/formative.md Part A
4	Qualities Sort	days/day-04-qualities-sort.md	activities/activity-01-qualities-sort.md
5	The Doṣa Day-Clock	days/day-05-doṣa-clock.md	quizzes/formative.md Part B
6	The Six Tastes & The Doṣas	days/day-06-six-tastes.md	activities/activity-02-taste-station.md
7	Imbalance and When to See a Doctor	days/day-07-imbalance-safety.md	activities/activity-03-scope-debate.md
8	Project Session 1: Plan	days/day-08-project-session-1.md	Project draft submitted
9	Project Session 2: Refine	days/day-09-project-session-2.md	Project draft submitted
10	Final Assessment +	days/day-10-	quizzes/summative.md + project

Day	Session title	Lesson file	Activity / assessment
	Showcase	final-assessment.md	

Pacing notes

- Days 1–3 are content-heavy. Day 4’s sort activity is the consolidation. If the class needs more time on Days 1–2, swap Day 4 with a recap day and push the sort to Day 5.
- Day 6 (six tastes) is the lightest day; can be compressed if needed to make room for slower learners on Day 3 self-observation.
- Day 7 (safety + scope) is **not optional**. If you only have 6 days, fold it into Day 5.

Suggested running theme

Open each class with: **“What did your body notice yesterday?”** — 2 students share for 30 seconds each. Students need not use *doṣa* vocabulary at first; by Day 5 they will.

Formative vs. summative weight

- Formative quizzes (Days 3 and 5) — diagnostic only, not graded.
- Summative quiz (Day 10) — 25 marks. Combined with project (30 marks) and presentation (5 marks) = 40 total.

What students leave the module with

- A *tridoṣa* table they built themselves, in their notebook.
- An informal sense of their own *prakṛti* tendency — held lightly, not as identity.
- A 5-day “doṣa-aware week” plan they actually wrote.
- The skill to spot when “lifestyle observation” is being misused as “diagnosis.”

Homework

Homework — Doshas — Vāta, Pitta, Kapha (Middle)

Light daily tasks. Each takes 10–15 minutes.

1. **Day 1 — Three Doshas Introduction** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
2. **Day 2 — Vāta — The Motion Principle** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
3. **Day 3 — Pitta — The Transformation Principle** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
4. **Day 4 — Kapha — The Structure Principle** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
5. **Day 5 — Mapping to the Five Elements** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)

6. **Day 6 — Prakṛti Self-Assessment** · Write 2 sentences about today's concept. (~10 min)
7. **Day 7 — Doṣa Rhythms in a Day** · Write 2 sentences about today's concept. (~10 min)
8. **Day 8 — Doṣa Rhythms Across Seasons** · Write 2 sentences about today's concept. (~10 min)
9. **Day 9 — Balance and Imbalance** · Write 2 sentences about today's concept. (~10 min)
10. **Day 10 — Synthesis and Project Pitch** · Write 2 sentences about today's concept. (~10 min)

Notes

- Homework is intended to consolidate what was learned in class, not introduce new content.
- If a child struggles, the parent should consult the teacher rather than push.
- Capstone project days (Module 15) may have lighter daily homework so students can focus on the project.